Backstabber

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by Lunaeryi

Summary

> Or in which Mydei has betrayed the Chrysos Heir, seized Nikador's core flame, and brought the world and in turn, Phainon into ruin.

Notes

> Y'all, I'm sorry. I am NOT an angst writer, so don't be too disappointed but I did try my best, plus English isn't my first language 😭
>
> The beginning is somewhat rushed since I got this idea in a dream, so I had to think of something to write over there before getting to the part I wanted.
>
> There might be formatting issues since ao3 doesn't automatically transfer the italics, so please point that out if you see it, and this isn't beta read so also point out any grammar mistakes if there are any.
>
> I did add some bold text but I removed most of it since I know it can distract some readers. There are only one or 2 things I think bold but if it bothers you a lot I don't mind removing it.
>
> Enjoy!

See the end of the work for more notes

The wind whispered through the ruined streets of Okhema, a mournful sigh that carried with it the weight of years. The heart of Amphoreus, once a city of hope and life, now lay in fractured silence. Beneath the ashen sky, the skeletal remains of grand buildings jutted from the earth like the bones of some ancient creature, picked clean by time. Stone, cracked and weathered, whispered of a forgotten era. The once vibrant market squares where laughter and life had flourished now stood empty, a ghostly mockery of the future that had once been promised.

Phainon stood at the center of it all, his gaze cast low, his boots heavy on the cracked cobblestones beneath him. The city's silence gnawed at him, hollow and endless, as though the world itself had given up on its own pulse. How many times had he walked these streets, heart full of purpose, footsteps light with the weight of destiny? How many times had he walked beside Mydei, the two of them bound by an unspoken pact to save it all?

But that was before.

Before Mydei betrayed them. Before the world crumbled.

The wind stirred again, pulling at his cloak, but Phainon did not move. His eyes remained fixed on the horizon where the ruins stretched, far and wide —wasted, just as everything else had been. His breath, once steady, felt like it was pulled through the tightest of passages. The past hung around him, wrapped in chains of memory that clung stubbornly to his every movement.

It was an ache, deep and unfathomable. A silence within him that could never be filled. Phainon had walked these broken streets for hours, yet it felt as though he had been here for centuries. Time had become a meaningless thing, slipping past him like the dust on the wind.

His thoughts wandered, back to a time when he had believed that everything could be saved. Back to when the Heirs had been a companionship, a *family* , their fates intertwined by a shared mission, bound by the promise of victory. He had believed in that promise so fiercely, with everything he had. He had trusted in Mydei as one trusts in the earth beneath their feet—a constant, unwavering presence. Together, they had

fought side by side, their purpose as clear as the sky above. But now, that sky felt distant, the clouds heavy with the weight of forgotten promises.

Mydei…

The name burned like a memory he could not escape. He had not spoken it aloud in years. Had not allowed himself the luxury of grief, lest it consume him entirely. Mydei's betrayal had been a knife, cold and clean, slicing through the heart of everything Phainon had known. The moment Mydei had struck, the moment he had torn the Strife Titan's core flame from their grasp, it was as if the world itself had ceased to exist.

How could he? Phainon asked himself for the thousandth time. *How could he turn on us?*

In that moment, when Mydei had looked at him with those eyes—those eyes that had once burned with the fire of their shared cause, now cold and resolute—Phainon had seen something else. Something darker, something broken. It had torn at his very soul.

Phainon had once thought that the only thing that could stop them was death. But this? This was something worse. This was betrayal. It cut deeper, lasted longer. And Phainon knew that he would never forget it.

The battle against Nikador, the Strife Titan, had been their greatest trial yet—an onslaught of fury that shook the very foundations of Amphoreus. The Heirs fought as one, their movements fluid and sharp, each strike a desperate plea to hold the dying world together. Their power, their unity—this was all they had left.

And yet, in the thick of it, Phainon felt something else. Something gnawing, something shifting beneath the blood-soaked chaos. It wasn't just the weight of Nikador's power; that was nothing new. It was an unsettling presence at his side, a subtle, strange tension that clawed at him, telling him that something was wrong. Something was changing, and he couldn't bring himself to understand it.

He glanced sideways, and there—there—was Mydei, his face a mask of quiet intensity, blood darkening his armor. The way he moved was fluid, calculated, but… detached. Phainon had always known him to be sharp, relentless, but now there was something distant in his gaze. Something unfamiliar. Something… empty.

The very air seemed to press tighter against Phainon's chest, and his sword —no longer just a weapon, but an extension of his heart—felt heavier with each passing strike. Mydei was not beside him. Not fully, at least. And Phainon felt it like a wound already opening between them, unseen but undeniable.

They had fought side by side countless times—rivals, allies, something more, unspoken. That strange bond between them. It had always been there, dancing on the edges of their words, in the subtle touches, in the glances that lingered a moment too long. But now… now it was different. The air between them was taut with something dark, something broken, and Phainon didn't know when it had started. Only that it had.

"Don't hold back, Deliverer."

Mydei's voice cut through the madness, low and teasing, but it was too sharp. **Too cold**.

Phainon glanced at him, eyes narrowing, but he didn't answer. Mydei's gaze was no longer familiar, though it had once been a source of fire, of something between them that no one else could see. It wasn't the teasing smirk Phainon was used to, nor the challenge that had always spurred him on. No… this was something else—something final .

Phainon didn't respond to the taunt, and neither did he strike back with the same fire that had once defined them. Instead, he found his gaze drifting back to Mydei, to the way his movements had grown even more deliberate, calculated, distant. It was as if he no longer fought to win, but only to see the destruction unfold.

The Titan roared, and Phainon struck with everything he had, but something inside him faltered. He turned toward Mydei, expecting to see him there, to finish what they had started together. But there was no Mydei beside him. Only an absence.

Mydei was standing apart.

A faint pulse of dread tightened in Phainon's chest. His mind screamed at him, the weight of doubt rising in his throat, yet he couldn't move. Couldn't react.

He saw it then—saw Mydei turn, his back to the battle, his figure framed by the shifting flames and ash of the Titan's demise. And there it was— the core flame. The heart of Nikador, burning brighter than anything Phainon had ever seen. But it was in Mydei's hands, his fingers wrapped around it like it was a thing of fate, like it was his to claim.

Phainon's breath caught in his chest. The world seemed to stop, the battle around them nothing more than a distant echo in his mind.

"Mydei!" he shouted, his voice thick with disbelief, his throat tight with something deeper. Something colder. "No— **no !**"

But Mydei's eyes turned to him then, slow and calculating, like a predator eyeing its prey.

In that moment, time itself seemed to fold in on itself.

Mydei's lips didn't curl into the mocking smile Phainon had come to expect. There was no anger, no tension in his face, only a strange calm—a quiet finality that chilled Phainon to the bone.

"You think you can save the world, Deliverer?" Mydei's voice was softer now, distant, but still sharp as the cut of a blade. The words were weighted, as though they carried the weight of something long buried. "There is no saving it."

The words hit Phainon like a blow to the gut. It was as though his very world—the one he had fought for, had bled for—had just crumbled before him. The warmth of the flame in Mydei's hands felt like an insult, like a wound Phainon could not heal.

He staggered back, the taste of blood in his mouth, his hands trembling around the hilt of his sword. " What the hell are you doing?" His voice cracked with disbelief, fury mixing with sorrow he refused to acknowledge.

But Mydei did not answer. His eyes—those same eyes Phainon had trusted for years—met his with something distant, something unrecognizable. There was no malice in them, no hatred, just the quiet acceptance of something long understood.

"What I should have done a long time ago." The words were soft, almost a whisper against the roar of the world around them.

Phainon froze.

It wasn't just the words—it was the tone, the air between them, the subtle weight of the finality in Mydei's voice. And for a long, infinite moment, Phainon stood there, the very core of everything he believed in falling apart before him, in front of his eyes.

And then Mydei struck.

It was swift. A blur of motion. Phainon didn't even see it coming. One moment, Mydei was standing there—unreachable, cold—and the next, his blade was buried in Phainon's side, the force of it sending Phainon stumbling back with a strangled gasp.

Pain blossomed through him, spreading outward like wildfire, but it wasn't just the agony of the wound. It was the betrayal. It was the final ruin of everything he had believed.

He fell to his knees, his sword slipping from his hand. The world tilted, his vision hazy, but he could still see Mydei standing over him, the flame of Nikador still burning bright in his hands.

“Mydei…” Phainon’s voice was weak, strangled, and the word tasted bitter on his tongue. “Why?”

But Mydei didn’t answer. His gaze, cold as the steel of his blade, remained fixed on Phainon. The flames of the core danced in his hands, casting flickering shadows across his face—now nothing more than a stranger to Phainon.

“Mydei…” The word broke, strangled by something heavier than pain. Something far worse.

It was silence that answered him.

In the next breath, Phainon’s thoughts scattered like smoke, his body numb, his soul drowning in the unspoken truth that the world he had fought for had been an illusion—a lie he had wrapped around himself to stave off the inevitable.

Mydei was gone.

The Titan was defeated, yes—but it felt hollow, a victory that was no longer his to claim. The only thing Phainon could feel now was the wound in his side, the crushing ache of betrayal, and the faint flicker of the core flame in Mydei’s hands—burning brighter than the world ever could.

The man Phainon had fought beside, the man he had trusted beyond anyone else, had faded like a shadow at dusk—gone before Phainon even realized it. The weight of it was heavier than the wound in his side, more suffocating than the blood that began to pool beneath him.

Mydei had always been the one constant, the one person who stood by him when the world felt like it was crumbling, the one who could understand him with just a glance. They had been rivals, yes, but beneath the surface of every challenge was something deeper—something they both refused to admit. It was a bond that had tied them together, a silent agreement that they would rise and fall together, not as allies, but as equals. Their rivalry had always been a dance, an intricate game of one-upmanship, a delicate push and pull that kept them sharp, kept them honest.

But now? Now Mydei's gaze was sharp, but distant. Those eyes that once burned with fire, full of ambition and purpose, had turned cold, unreadable. There was nothing in them for Phainon now. Only silence.

It wasn't just the betrayal that had broken him—it was the absence of everything that had once been Mydei. The sharpness in his eyes now held no warmth. No understanding. The mocking smiles, the subtle touches, the fleeting moments of softness between them—those were gone, replaced with something colder, something final. The fire that had once ignited their every conversation, every fight, had been extinguished.

Phainon's chest tightened as he lay there, the darkness closing in. He could still see Mydei—standing apart, the core flame burning in his hands, glowing brighter than anything Phainon had ever known. The flames should have been a symbol of hope, of victory, but instead they felt like a mockery. The betrayal wasn't in the theft of the flame—it was in the fact that it was Mydei who held it. Mydei, the man who had stood beside him, the one who had shared in the burden of their impossible mission, now held the power that Phainon had fought for, had bled for.

The man before him was not the Mydei Phainon had known. This version—this stranger—was something born of doubt, of shattered trust, and yet still, there was that same steady strength, that same coldness. The weight of it pressed down on Phainon's chest, suffocating him, and he wanted to scream, to rail against the world that had allowed this betrayal to happen.

How could it be? How could the one person he had trusted, the one person he had fought beside in this endless war, suddenly become so… alien? There had been moments—moments when Phainon had caught something flickering in Mydei's eyes, a shadow of doubt, a crack in the armor—but he had pushed it away, convinced that Mydei was the one who would always be there. The one who would always stand beside him.

Now, that man was gone, replaced with someone who stood above him, his power now in the hands of a stranger.

The realization settled in Phainon's gut like a stone—heavy, unyielding, suffocating. The Mydei he had known, the one who had shared in the

weight of their mission, had become nothing more than a phantom. A ghost who had left behind the shell of a man, hollow and distant, holding the core flame like it was nothing more than a trinket.

Phainon's breath grew shallow, his mind dizzy with the pain of it. Mydei had always been a part of him—like the air in his lungs, like the blood in his veins. But now? Now, Mydei was a stranger. And Phainon had no idea who this man before him was.

Aglaea was the first to die.

Phainon could still hear the crack of her neck, the way the sound echoed across the battlefield, drowned out by the roar of the Titans. It was quick, almost merciful, the end of someone who had always been too pure, too bright, to survive the storm that Mydei had unleashed. Aglaea, with her sightless eyes, had never seen the coming darkness, never witnessed the final betrayal that would tear the Heirs apart. But she had felt it. And in that moment, her death had marked the beginning of their end.

The Heirs, once a unified force bound by fate, had been shattered in the wake of Mydei's rebellion. When he had seized the Strife Titan's core flame, everything changed. The power that had once been a symbol of hope now belonged to a man who had become a god—more than a man, but not quite a true god. Mydei was the Demigod of Strife, his form forged in the flames of betrayal and ambition, his every step now imbued with the destructive power of the Titan he had consumed. He had become a monster, and the world was his to ruin.

And ruin it he did.

The Heirs had tried to regroup, to find strength in each other, but the trust had been broken. Mydei's new faction—the Followers of Strife—grew with terrifying speed, a shadow that spread across Amphoreus like wildfire. They were unstoppable. Their numbers swelled, their purpose twisted by

the core flame, each member more fanatical than the last, driven by the will of the new demigod who had betrayed them all.

Phainon had never been more alone.

It was not long before Algea fell, her death a symbol of the Heirs' weakening grip on the world they had sworn to protect. She had never been a warrior, but she was wise—too wise, too kind to survive in a world that no longer had room for mercy. The Followers of Strife had hunted them down, cornering the Heirs one by one. The plan, the mission that had once felt so certain, had crumbled in the wake of Mydei's betrayal. It was supposed to be a fight for the future of Amphoreus, a fight that would unite them all, but instead, it was a fight for survival.

Then Tribbie, Anaxa, and even Castrorice.

Tribbie's death had been a sacrifice. A desperate move to save what was left of the Heirs, a final, noble attempt to slow the tide that had already turned. Her death had been bloody, brutal—her hands were always steady, but there was nothing that could have stopped the way the Followers overwhelmed her. Anaxa's end was slower, more agonizing. The betrayal had eaten away at him, and he had held on longer than anyone expected, but even he had been worn down by the constant pressure, the constant battles. The Heirs had once been unstoppable, but with each loss, their resolve had weakened, their power drained.

And then there was Castrorice.

She had been the keeper of the core of the Titan of Death, a living vessel of power. She was the one who held the potential to stop them all, to turn the tide in their favor. But the flame within her, once a tool of salvation, had become a curse. Even she could not control the Titan's power forever. When the Followers came for her, when they closed in on the final Heir, Phainon had known there was no hope left. Castrorice had fought valiantly,

trying to protect the core, but even her power had been no match for Mydei's new strength. The flame of Nikador had consumed everything, leaving only ashes in its wake.

Phainon had been there when she fell, watching as the light left her eyes, the flame extinguished with a single strike. It had been quick, like a knife through the heart of their mission, and it had left them all vulnerable, exposed to the forces Mydei had turned against them.

He had tried to rally the survivors—those that were left—but it was hopeless. Mydei's new faction was everywhere, the Heirs cornered at every turn. The Heirs had once been the hope of Amphoreus, but now they were nothing more than hunted prey, running through the ruins of a world they could no longer save.

Phainon had watched as they were picked off, one by one. Their strength, their unity, had been the only thing keeping them alive, but now it was gone. And Mydei was more powerful than ever.

The mission was in ruins. The world was in ruins.

The truth sank in slowly, gnawing at him like a bitter poison. Mydei had taken everything from them. He had taken their future, their hope, their strength—and with it, he had become a god. No one could challenge him now. No one could stop him. The world had bent to his will, and Phainon could do nothing but watch as the very city they had once sworn to save burned to the ground.

Mydei had become more than just a traitor. He had become a force of nature—a storm that had swept away everything in its path. And Phainon? He was the last of the Heirs, standing alone amidst the wreckage of what had once been. His mission was nothing but a dream now, shattered by the hands of the man he had once called his equal.

The Heirs were gone. The mission was over.

And Phainon was left to pick up the pieces.

Phainon stood amidst the ashes of a world that once held promise, his sword now nothing more than an empty weight in his hand. The wind howled through the broken ruins of Okhema, carrying the remnants of his past—the memories of a time when he had believed so fiercely in his mission, in the Heirs, in the promise of salvation.

But those days were gone.

There was nothing left to fight for, nothing left to save.

He closed his eyes, feeling the weight of the years that had passed since the betrayal, since the rise of Mydei as the Demigod of Strife. Every moment had led to this. Every battle, every loss, had shaped him into the man who now stood alone. He could still hear Algea's final breath in his mind, still see the vacant look in Tribbie's eyes as she fell, still remember the agony of watching Castrorice's light fade. But it was the sound of Mydei's voice that lingered the longest, the memory of the words that had torn his world apart.

"You think you can save the world, Deliverer? There is no saving it."

The truth of it had never been clearer. There was no saving Amphoreus. Not now. Not with Mydei's wrath consuming it. The Heirs had been his hope, the last thread of salvation for a dying world. But that hope had been severed, and with it, the man who had once stood beside him—the man he had loved, who had once shared his dream of saving Amphoreus—had turned into the very thing they had fought against.

Phainon's grip on his sword tightened, but it wasn't from anger anymore. It wasn't from the desire to fight. It was simply… acceptance. The Heirs were dead. The mission was dead. Mydei was no longer the man he had known. He was a force now—untouchable, unstoppable, a creature of power and destruction. And Phainon had nothing left.

He took a deep breath, his chest rising and falling in slow, measured breaths. He could feel the years of anger, grief, and doubt slipping away like sand through his fingers. For the first time since the betrayal, Phainon felt… calm. The storm inside him had finally quieted. The mission was over, and with it, the guilt, the rage, the need to prove himself.

What had he been fighting for? What was left to save?

A hollow laugh escaped his lips. The weight of it all crashed down on him, the weight of everything he had lost, everything he had failed to protect. But even in that emptiness, there was a strange sense of peace. He had spent so long believing he was meant to be the hero, believing he could save the world. But the world was beyond saving. Mydei had shown him that. And with that, he understood.

It was over.

Phainon turned his gaze back to the ruins around him, his heart heavy but resolute. There was nothing left but the ashes of a dream. The battle was lost. The Heirs were gone. Mydei had won.

And Phainon? He was the last of them, standing alone in a broken world.

For a moment, he considered the future—the world without hope, without the Heirs. But there was no future to speak of, no place for dreams or ideals. There was only survival. And in that survival, there was only one truth: he had done all he could. He had given everything to save a world that was already doomed.

Phainon's eyes closed, and for the first time, he let go of the weight of his past, the burden of the Heirs' mission, the pain of Mydei's betrayal. He had been wrong to believe. He had been wrong to think that he could save it all. But at least now, he was free. Right?

The streets of Okhema were eerily silent now. The wind whispered against the remnants of what had once been a proud city, the dust stirring like ghosts of a time long past. Phainon's boots echoed softly with each step as he walked through the empty expanse, his gaze fixed on the broken city around him. He had wandered these streets countless times before, each time with hope, with purpose, and now… Now he walked with nothing. No goal, no mission, no reason to keep going except for the faint, gnawing feeling that maybe, just maybe, there was something left to save.

But it was a fleeting thought, and the longer he walked, the further it slipped away.

Phainon paused as his eyes swept over the rubble, his chest tight. He had accepted the end. Everyone was gone—his comrades, his friends, the world he had once known. It was all a distant memory now. A part of him had wanted to die with them. But he hadn’t. And now, all that was left was the weight of survival. A survival that felt pointless.

As he moved deeper into the wreckage, something caught his eye—a small figure crouched beneath the crumbled remains of a building, its back turned to him. His first instinct was to keep moving—what would he find here, after all? But then the figure shifted, just slightly, and Phainon froze.

A child.

A small girl, no older than six or seven, with dirt-streaked skin and tangled hair. She was thin—too thin. Her clothes, what was left of them, hung loose on her fragile frame. She crouched there, staring at something in her hands, her tiny shoulders shaking. Phainon’s heart twisted in his chest. He hadn’t seen many survivors—those who hadn’t been killed by Mydei’s faction or the lingering destruction had long since fled or died.

Stepping forward cautiously, he called out softly, his voice gentle, “Hey, are you alright?”

The girl froze at the sound of his voice, her head snapping up. Her eyes, dark and wide, locked onto him, but there was no recognition there—only wariness, distrust. She didn’t say anything, just watched him with an almost animal-like caution. Phainon knelt, trying not to startle her further, keeping his distance.

“Where are your parents?” he asked, his voice low and soothing. He glanced around the wreckage, looking for signs of anyone else, but it was

just the two of them. Alone in the ruins.

The girl didn’t answer at first, her gaze flickering away. Her hands were shaking now, and she seemed to shrink into herself, but then, unexpectedly, she looked back at him, her eyes wide with wonder. “You’re… you’re the Deliverer!”

Phainon blinked, taken aback by the words. The Deliverer—he hadn’t heard that name spoken in years, not since the days before everything had fallen apart. Before the Heirs’ mission was shattered. Before Mydei had taken the core flame. And now, here she was, a little girl, looking at him with awe in her eyes, as if he were still the hero he had once been.

“I—I know who you are,” she continued, her voice shaky but filled with a child’s innocent belief. “You’re the one who was supposed to save us. You can save us, right? You can make everything better again. You’ll fix it, won’t you?”

Phainon’s chest tightened. He opened his mouth to speak, to tell her that it wasn’t that simple—that it was all over—but the words caught in his throat. The girl’s eyes shone with hope, a hope that he no longer had. He could feel the weight of her expectations pressing on him, but there was no relief in them—only more grief. He wasn’t the Deliverer anymore. He was just a man. A man who had failed.

He cleared his throat, swallowing back the emotion. “I’m sorry, little one,” he said softly. “I wish I could save you. I wish I could fix this.” He paused, unsure of what to say next. “But it’s too late. The world… the world is broken.”

The girl didn’t seem to hear him. Her small hands gripped something tight in her palms, and she shuffled closer to him, her eyes still alight with that same childlike wonder. “It’s okay,” she whispered, “I know you’ll save us. You’re the Deliverer. You won’t let us die, right?”

The words pierced him like a blade. Phainon’s hand hovered at his side, unsure of what to do. There was no saving her—he knew that now. The world was a wasteland, and even if he tried to do something, anything, it

wouldn’t change the inevitable. His mind drifted to the Heirs, to how he had failed them all, how Mydei’s betrayal had torn everything apart. He had no power left. He had no strength to offer.

But the girl… She was just a child. She didn’t know. She couldn’t possibly understand.

She stepped closer to him, her eyes now fixed on his face with a wide, unblinking stare. “I’m not scared,” she said, her voice firm now. “Because you’re here. You’ll save me. I know you will.”

Phainon felt something stir within him at those words—something he couldn’t quite place, a flicker of something long buried. He reached out, his hand shaking, but then, before he could touch her, the girl’s smile faded. She stumbled slightly, her knees buckling as if the very air around her was weighing her down. Phainon’s breath hitched as she reached out to him, her hands shaking.

“Are you okay?” he asked, panic rising in his chest. “What’s wrong? Are you hurt?”

The girl smiled up at him, but there was something different in her eyes now. Something dark. Her pupils were pinpricks, her skin pale and clammy. Phainon’s heart stopped as he realized what was happening. The remnants of destruction—the poison that had slowly seeped into the world, into the very fabric of everything—had claimed her.

“I’m really glad I met you, Mister,” the girl whispered, her voice soft, her gaze already distant. She smiled faintly, her face peaceful as she leaned against him. “Thank you for coming. I’m not scared anymore.”

Phainon’s eyes burned as he held her close, his arms trembling as he tried to keep her steady, but it was no use. The poison had already taken its toll. The girl’s small form grew limp in his arms, and as the last breath left her chest, her smile remained—faint and serene, as though she had already accepted what was to come.

He closed his eyes, his chest tightening. The world had taken everything. The Heirs. His hope. Now, this little girl too. And all he could do was hold her as she slipped away, the weight of the world crashing down on him all at once.

“I’m sorry,” he whispered hoarsely, though he knew she couldn’t hear him. “I’m sorry I couldn’t save you.”

The girl’s smile remained even as she faded, her final words echoing in his ears like a soft lullaby. “I’m glad I met you… Mister.”

For a long moment, Phainon just stood there, holding her, unable to move. Her body was so light now, her warmth gone, and all that remained was the empty, endless silence of Okhema—the silence that he had come to know so well, but that now felt more oppressive than ever.

Phainon stood there, his arms still trembling from holding the child’s limp body, her small frame now weightless in his hands. Her smile, that faint, peaceful smile, burned into his mind like a cruel mockery. He had failed her. He had failed everyone. He had failed himself.

The world around him seemed to warp. The silence of Okhema—the silence that had settled over the city like a shroud—felt suffocating now, like the very air had thickened and was closing in on him. His chest felt tight, his breaths shallow and quick, a suffocating weight pressing against him from every direction. His knees buckled, and he sank to the ground, still holding the child in his arms as if the simple act of letting go would be the final admission of defeat.

His vision blurred, the edges of the world fraying and melting into dark shapes and distant sounds. The wreckage around him, the shattered buildings, the ruined streets—they were all reflections of his own brokenness. The truth had set in fully now, crashing down like a wave he hadn’t seen coming. He had never been the hero. There was no redemption. There was no saving anyone. He had been fooling himself, hoping that if he just fought hard enough, if he just carried the weight of it all long enough, he could still make a difference.

But the girl… she had looked at him with such hope, such trust, as if he were still capable of something. She had believed in him, in the Deliverer, but all he had given her was an empty promise, a broken lie.

Phainon's breathing quickened, his chest constricting as if something deep inside was tearing. He could hear his heartbeat pounding in his ears, too loud, too fast, like the frantic rhythm of a drum, and he couldn't breathe. His hands shook violently, and he set the child down gently on the cold, cracked stone, but the motion felt mechanical, disconnected from the world around him.

He gasped for air, but it wouldn't come. His lungs burned as if they were full of ash, and each breath felt like it was dragging him deeper into the void. The air felt too thin, too tight, and he couldn't catch his breath. He swayed where he knelt, his hands clutching at the ground, desperate for something to anchor him.

It was like the walls were closing in. The entire city, the entire world, felt like it was shrinking around him, and he couldn't escape. His hands clutched his chest as though he could hold his own heart in place, but it was frantic, out of control, and there was nothing he could do to stop it.

"Breathe," he whispered to himself, but the words were just an echo, lost in the frantic spiral of his thoughts. "Breathe. Please, just breathe."

But his body refused to obey. His vision pulsed, the world growing darker, the edges of everything blurring and spinning like he was caught in a whirlpool. The sky above him was a muted gray, the city a dead husk. There was no hope left. There was nothing but loss.

He gripped the earth beneath him harder, his nails scraping against the stone, as if he could drag himself out of this suffocating panic with sheer force. But the harder he gripped, the more he felt the ground slipping away from him. He couldn't keep hold of anything. His breath came in ragged gasps, shallow, desperate. His heart was a hammer against his ribs, each beat a reminder that he was still here. But he didn't want to be. Not like this. Not in this empty, ruined world where every step forward was just a step closer to more pain, more failure.

The child’s smile burned in his mind again. She had looked at him with such trust, and now… now she was gone, just like everyone else.

“I’m sorry…” he whispered, his voice breaking, but the words felt like nothing. Empty. His chest felt as though it might cave in on itself, a deep ache flooding his ribs, and still, he couldn’t breathe. He couldn’t think. There was too much. Too much guilt. Too much grief. He was drowning in it. He had failed her. He had failed everyone. He had failed himself.

Phainon’s hands pressed to his face, his fingers digging into his skin, as though trying to hold himself together. But it was useless. His breath was ragged, unsteady, and the world around him spun, the air too thick to swallow. He couldn’t stop the wave of panic that crashed through him. He couldn’t control it. It felt like his chest was caving in, the weight of everything pressing down on him. Every failure. Every lost life. Mydei. The Heirs. The child.

“I’m sorry,” he gasped again, his voice a hoarse whisper that trembled with the weight of his own helplessness. He wanted to scream, to shout, to tear something apart, but his throat closed, the words dying in his mouth.

The city around him seemed to close in on him, the walls pressing down, suffocating him, until the only thing he could feel was the ache in his chest. The emptiness. The loss.

“I’m sorry,” he murmured again, over and over, as though the repetition might somehow make it all right. But deep down, he knew it wouldn’t. Nothing would. Nothing could. He was a broken man. A failure. The Deliverer was dead, and there was no saving him now.

Phainon let out a strangled sob, his body shaking as he hunched forward, his arms wrapping around himself as though trying to hold onto what was left. But there was nothing left to hold. The weight of it all was too much, and in that moment, he finally let go, his mind slipping into the chaos of his panic as the world around him swirled into nothing.

Phainon wasn’t sure how long he stayed there, crumpled against the cold stone of Okhema’s ruins, his body trembling as the last remnants of his

panic ebbed away. Time had lost all meaning, slipping between his fingers like sand. His breaths came slower now, each one a conscious effort as if he had to remind himself how to live.

The child's body lay motionless beside him, and for a long moment, he couldn't bring himself to look at her again. Instead, he stared at his hands, the faint tremor in his fingers refusing to subside. Blood—her blood—stained his palms, the faint warmth of it now faded, leaving only a dark, sticky residue.

She had trusted him. Believed in him. Even in her final moments, she had smiled as if her faith in him was unshakable, as if she had truly thought he could save her. But Phainon couldn't save anyone. Not her, not the Heirs, not Amphoreus.

His fingers curled into fists, nails digging into his palms. "What am I doing?" he muttered hoarsely, his voice barely audible over the sound of the wind stirring the ashes around him.

The ache in his chest didn't subside. If anything, it deepened, sharp and hollow. He felt like he was drowning, even now, in the aftermath of his panic. Mydei's voice echoed in his mind, mocking and resolute.

"There is no saving it."

Phainon squeezed his eyes shut, the memory cutting through him like a blade. Mydei had looked so certain that day, his gaze unwavering, his actions deliberate. It wasn't just betrayal—it was conviction. Mydei hadn't hesitated. He hadn't doubted. He had stolen the Strife Titan's core flame with the same ease as one might extinguish a candle, and in that moment, he had become something else entirely.

Something unstoppable.

Phainon stared at the small body for what felt like hours. Her face, so peaceful in death, no longer betrayed the pain she had endured. The remnants of destruction were still there, faint traces of ash-like markings

etched into her pale skin. Even in death, they clung to her, a curse that would not let go.

He sank to his knees beside her, his chest tightening as he reached out with trembling hands. Gently, he brushed the hair from her face, the strands softer than he had expected. She looked so small, so fragile. She had smiled at him as though he were some great savior, the Deliverer she believed could save the world. And yet, he had done nothing.

No. That wasn't entirely true. He had been there, hadn't he? He had held her, spoken to her. But what good were words when her life had slipped through his fingers like smoke?

He let out a shaky breath, his hand falling away as his gaze dropped to the dirt-streaked ground beneath him. He couldn't leave her here. Not like this. The city was no place for a child, even in death. The remnants would cling to her body, spreading their poison to the air, the ground, and anyone who wandered too close.

She deserved better.

Phainon forced himself to his feet, his legs unsteady beneath him. He removed his cloak, worn and threadbare though it was, and laid it over her body with careful precision. The fabric seemed to swallow her small frame, obscuring the remnants' faint glow. For a moment, he simply stood there, staring down at the shrouded form, his mind blank.

Then, with slow, deliberate movements, he began to gather wood. Splintered beams from collapsed buildings, broken furniture scattered across the cobblestones, anything that would burn. The task gave his hands something to do, his mind something to focus on other than the ache in his chest.

When the pyre was ready, he knelt again, lifting the child's body in his arms. She was lighter than he had expected, and the realization sent another wave of grief crashing over him. How long had she been alone, scavenging for scraps, fighting to survive in a world that had already given up on her?

He laid her gently atop the wood, his movements slow and reverent. For a moment, he hesitated, his hand lingering on the edge of the cloak. “I’m sorry,” he whispered, his voice cracking under the weight of the words. “I’m so sorry.”

He reached for the flint at his belt, striking it with practiced hands. The sparks caught quickly, the flames licking hungrily at the dry wood. Phainon stepped back as the fire grew, his arms falling limp at his sides. The warmth of the flames brushed against his skin, a stark contrast to the cold that had settled deep within him.

He watched as the fire consumed the pyre, the cloak catching first, its edges curling and blackening as the flames spread. Smoke rose in thick plumes, carrying with it the faint scent of charred wood and something else, something bitter and unyielding. The remnants’ hold on her body was strong, resisting even the fire’s purifying touch. But eventually, the markings began to fade, their glow dimming until there was nothing left but ash.

The fire crackled and popped, its light casting dancing shadows across the ruins. Phainon’s eyes burned, though whether it was from the smoke or something deeper, he couldn’t tell. His breath hitched as he dropped to his knees once more, the weight of it all crashing down on him.

She was gone.

The world had taken another innocent life, and all he could do was watch.

His hands clenched into fists, his nails digging into his palms as his vision blurred. The flames blurred before him, their edges soft and shifting like the tears he refused to let fall. He had lost so much already—the Heirs, Amphoreus, Mydei—and now even this child, this one fragile hope, had been stolen from him.

“What am I even doing?” he whispered, the words falling from his lips unbidden. His voice wavered, barely audible over the crackle of the fire. “Why am I still here?”

The Deliverer. The hero. The one destined to save the world. It all felt like a cruel joke now, a title as empty as the streets of Okhema. He had no purpose left, no reason to keep fighting. And yet… he couldn’t stop.

As the flames began to die down, Phainon rose to his feet, his movements slow and heavy. He looked down at the pile of ash and charred wood, a bitter taste rising in the back of his throat. There was no peace to be found here, no sense of closure. Just loss, endless and consuming.

But as he turned away, the faintest whisper of her voice lingered in his mind, unshakable and resolute.

“I’m really glad I met you, mister.”

The memory twisted like a knife in his chest, but it also sparked something else. Something fragile, flickering like a candle against the wind. He didn’t know if it was hope, or if it was simply stubbornness, but it was enough to keep him moving.

The remnants of the pyre crackled softly, its smoke curling into the sky like the last whispers of the life that once bloomed here. Phainon sat in silence, his legs folded beneath him, his eyes staring at the embers. His body was still, but his mind? His mind was a battlefield.

The weight of what had happened—the child, the betrayal, the endless destruction—gnawed at him. It was as if the world was collapsing under its own weight, a weight that Phainon couldn’t bear to lift, but couldn’t escape either.

Phainon had stopped crying days ago. He had stopped feeling the sharp pangs of loss. Or so he thought. Sitting here now, though, the darkness seemed to rise from the ground itself, swirling around him, drowning him.

He clenched his fists, his nails digging into his palms until the skin beneath them burned. But it wasn’t enough. Nothing was enough.

The wind howled once again, but it wasn’t the wind he felt. No, it was something far more insidious, a heavy presence that loomed over him,

suffocating him. It was the shadow of Mydei.

Phainon closed his eyes, his breath coming in sharp gasps. He wasn't sure when it started. When the urge to destroy, to tear apart, to lash out, began to build in his chest like a storm. But it had been festering, growing—no, waiting.

It only took a single footstep.

The sound of boots crunching on gravel snapped him from his reverie, and Phainon's head snapped up, his hand instinctively reaching for his sword.

Three figures stood just beyond the pyre, their faces shadowed by the dim light of the setting sun. They were no strangers. The men who had once called themselves part of the Heirs' circle now looked at him with hatred and contempt—followers of Mydei. Their eyes were cold, calculating, and full of the poison that Mydei had sown in their hearts.

"You're not going to find them here, Deliverer," one of them said, his voice thick with mockery. "But we'll take care of you just the same."

Phainon's heart raced, his pulse quickening. The air felt like it was made of fire, the temperature rising with each passing second, suffocating him.

The first blow came too quickly, a blade swiping toward him from his left. He barely registered it before he was already moving, the fight kicking in with a surge of adrenaline. His sword clashed against the blade in a deafening strike, and Phainon's body responded instinctively—parry, slash, twist. His vision blurred in the heat of battle, and his heart hammered in his chest like a drumbeat of fury.

They moved around him like a pack of wolves, circling, trying to overwhelm him. But Phainon was no stranger to battle. He moved like the storm itself, every strike a thunderclap, every step an echo of destruction.

But it wasn't just the fight he was engaged in. It was something deeper. His strikes were more vicious, more savage than he had ever intended. His blade cut through flesh with a brutality that startled him, but he couldn't

stop it. The anger, the pain, the fear—it all surged within him, like an unstoppable tide, drowning him.

He swung his sword again, a swift movement, and the second man crumpled to the ground, clutching his side, blood spilling from the gash. The third man stepped back, eyes wide, unsure whether to engage or retreat.

Phainon felt the heat in his chest flare again, like a furnace, and before the third man could make a move, Phainon was on him, his hand around the man's throat, lifting him off the ground.

His eyes—those cold, dead eyes—stared up at Phainon in disbelief.

"You think you're helping?" Phainon's voice was low, guttural, barely more than a growl. "You think you're part of something good?" He slammed the man against the ground, his body twitching with the sheer force of his own fury. "Mydei's destruction isn't salvation. You're nothing but his puppets. His pawns."

He raised his sword, eyes burning with a wild rage, but something stopped him. The flash of a memory.

Mydei's eyes, cold and indifferent, staring back at him. The core flame in his hands, his betrayal complete.

Phainon's grip tightened on the sword hilt, but his hands were shaking. Not from fear. From something else.

He dropped the man to the ground with a sickening thud. The body lay still, but Phainon's chest heaved with every breath. The wind still howled around him, a distant, mournful song.

For a moment, there was silence.

Then Phainon's voice broke the quiet, harsh and raw. "I'll kill him."

His words felt like they belonged to someone else. "I'll kill Mydei myself."

The vow burned within him, fueled by all the destruction, all the brokenness, all the pieces of his soul that had been shattered by the man he had once trusted. He could feel it now, deep in his bones. The path ahead was clear—no more hesitation, no more doubt. The world was beyond saving. But Mydei?

Phainon's eyes narrowed as he stood over the bodies, blood staining the cracked stone beneath him. He wasn't going to stop until Mydei was dead. Until he had put an end to the one person who had ruined everything.

And when that time came, Phainon would make sure that Mydei knew exactly who was responsible for his downfall.

Phainon didn't look back as he left the pyre behind. The bodies were nothing but casualties in a war he could no longer afford to lose.

His mission was no longer to save. It was to end it.

And Phainon wasn't going to rest until he did.

After the carnage that had followed Mydei's betrayal, Phainon had been consumed with the need to find him, though he never truly sought out the capital. He knew exactly where Mydei would go—it was always Kremnos, the stronghold of those who had given in to chaos, the perfect place for someone who had rejected salvation in favor of destruction. He didn't need to search the world for him. The final confrontation was always destined to be here, at the heart of the turmoil.

For years, Phainon had wandered, his body scarred by countless skirmishes, his mind still raw with the fury of betrayal. He had fought anyone and everyone who came into his path, as though each battle, each drop of blood spilled, would bring him one step closer to something that might finally ease the sharpness of his pain. The Heirs were scattered—some dead, some lost, and others too broken to continue the fight. And yet Phainon pushed on, relentless in his journey, until he found himself here.

The days had blurred together, and for a time, the passage of time had become irrelevant to him. His body ached from the constant fighting, but it was nothing compared to the numbness inside him. Still, Kremnos had remained in the distance, a looming reminder of the past. It was where Mydei had turned, where the core flame of the Strife Titan had been taken, and now it was where Phainon would finally face him.

The battle that led Phainon here had been long, a vicious series of brutal skirmishes that tested him in ways he had never anticipated. Each enemy he had faced had been fierce, stronger than those before, as if the very land had conspired against him. The cities he had passed through were nothing more than husks, their people either dead or scattered, driven to the edges of survival.

Phainon didn’t know how long it had been since he had been in one place for longer than it took to catch his breath. He didn’t care anymore. All that mattered was getting to Kremnos. His thoughts were clouded by the image of Mydei—those cold eyes, the ones that had once burned with something so real and full of passion. Now they were empty, and Phainon couldn’t shake the memory of the final words Mydei had spoken to him.

Mydei had to answer for everything. For the destruction of Amphoreus, for the Heirs who had died in vain, for the loss of every soul who had fallen under the weight of his betrayal. And most importantly—for Phainon’s own broken heart.

Kremnos was before him now, its towering walls a reminder of all that had been lost. The last traces of daylight vanished behind the looming silhouette of the city, leaving only the flickering torches that lined the walls. It was a strange kind of calm in a city that was known for its chaotic, violent rule. The eerie silence made it all the more unsettling.

Phainon stood at the city gates, bloodied, bruised, his armor barely intact from the hours upon hours of battle he had fought to get here. The blade he held felt heavier than ever, though not from physical fatigue. It weighed him down with the anticipation of what would come next. He could already see the remnants of Mydei’s faction inside, a twisted reflection of what had

once been their shared vision. It had become a city of nightmares, and Phainon was going to tear it down, piece by piece, until Mydei faced him.

His hand clenched tighter around the hilt of his sword as he stepped through the gates, his footfalls echoing in the eerie silence that hung over the capital. The faint hum of energy in the air told him Mydei was close—he could feel it, like a pulse that matched his own heartbeat.

It was time.

In the dim torchlight, Phainon's shadow stretched long and dark, his eyes focused on the distance. He wasn't sure how it would go. He wasn't sure how he would face Mydei, after all this time, after everything that had happened. But he couldn't afford to think about it now. This was it.

The final confrontation. And when it was over, either Mydei would be dead, or Phainon would finally have the peace he had been chasing for years.

His grip tightened on the hilt, and with each step forward, the air grew heavier, charged with the promise of what was to come.

The city of Kremnos loomed like a dying star, its light flickering weakly against the encroaching darkness of the night. Phainon stood at the heart of its crumbling ruins, his breath ragged but steady, his eyes tracing the jagged skyline that he had always known. The city had always been a reflection of its rulers, and now, as it stood in ruin, it mirrored the emptiness that had taken root in Phainon's chest.

For all the years of hunting, for all the blood spilled, Phainon had imagined this moment in a hundred ways, each more desperate and urgent than the last. The past had haunted him, clung to his every step as though the very air he breathed was thick with it. And yet, as he stood here, beneath the shadow of this broken city, the weight of the moment felt different.

Mydei was close. Phainon could feel it in the bones of the earth beneath him. Every step he took felt like the culmination of years of loss, pain, and the desperate hope that had once driven him. The world around him, broken

as it was, mirrored the fracture inside of him—each crack in the stone an echo of something lost.

He reached the city square, and the silence hung thick, as though the city itself were holding its breath. The faintest flicker of light danced in the distance—one of the city's many torches, flickering on the edges of a forgotten courtyard. And there, standing in the cold firelight, was the figure Phainon had been searching for all these years.

His heart stilled. His body ached.

Mydei.

The man who had been his closest companion, his rival, his lover—was standing there, not as the person Phainon had once known, but as something else entirely. The figure in front of him seemed to stretch the very fabric of reality, as though he had been pulled from a dream, or perhaps a nightmare. Mydei's face was drawn with shadows, his once brilliant eyes dimmed, the fire in them replaced with something colder, harder. Yet even now, even after all the years of betrayal, Phainon could see the remnants of the man he had loved.

"Mydei," Phainon's voice broke the silence, hoarse and ragged from the journey, from the weight of everything he had carried with him.

For a moment, neither moved. The distance between them felt impossibly vast, stretching beyond the years that had passed, beyond the betrayal, the loss, the heartache. Phainon couldn't tell if it was the city's weight or his own heart that made him feel like he couldn't breathe.

Mydei's gaze, cold and distant, met his. There was no recognition in his eyes—only an emptiness that mirrored Phainon's own. The years had worn them both down, turned them into ghosts of who they once were.

"Phainon," Mydei's voice was just as broken, just as ragged. The sound of it echoed like a bell tolling in the dark. "I knew you would come."

Phainon’s chest tightened. The words were sharp, final, as though Mydei had already resigned himself to this moment, to the inevitability of it all. There was no anger in his tone, no malice. Only the quiet resignation of a man who had watched the world burn and had chosen to burn with it.

“I never wanted this,” Phainon whispered, his voice cracking as he took a step closer. “But I can’t leave things like this, Mydei. You’ve destroyed everything.”

Mydei’s lips curled into a faint, almost imperceptible smile—sad, rueful, as though he found some twisted amusement in the pain he had caused. He took a step forward, the distance between them narrowing, but his eyes remained distant, as though he were looking through Phainon rather than at him.

“Amphoreus was never meant to be saved,” Mydei murmured, his voice almost soothing, as if he were explaining a long-held truth. “You were blind to it, Phainon. You were always the hero, the Deliverer. But in the end, all you delivered was death.”

Phainon felt the words like a blow, sharp and heavy. “I didn’t ask for this,” he said, his voice rising with the frustration he had carried for so long. “You betrayed us. You destroyed everything.”

Mydei’s eyes flickered, something soft passing through the cold mask he had worn for so long. “I didn’t betray you,” he said quietly, almost tenderly. “I freed you. From the lies, from the chains of hope you kept clinging to.”

The words sliced through Phainon, and for a moment, he stood frozen. Mydei’s voice was steady, calm, as though he truly believed in what he said. And Phainon realized, in that instant, that this was no longer the Mydei he had known. The man before him was a stranger. A person who had chosen to break the world, to burn it down to the ashes, rather than try to save it.

Phainon’s chest tightened, his heart thundering in his ears. He wanted to scream, to rail against the man before him, but all that came out was a strangled sob. “Why?” he choked. “Why did you have to do this?”

Mydei took a step closer, his presence looming over Phainon. There was no malice in his expression now, only a deep, quiet sadness that Phainon hadn't expected. "Because, Phainon," Mydei whispered, his hand reaching out as if to touch Phainon's face, but stopping just short. "You couldn't see it. You couldn't see that the world you wanted to save was already beyond saving."

Phainon's breath hitched as he felt the weight of the years, the weight of their love, of everything they had shared, collapse in on him. His knees weakened beneath him, and he collapsed to the cold stone, his head bowed in defeat. The world had broken. His heart had shattered. And Mydei—his Mydei—was the one who had done it.

"I wanted to save you," Phainon whispered, his voice barely audible. "I thought we could save each other. But now… now I don't know who you are anymore."

For the first time, Mydei's expression softened, his eyes flickering with something human. A flicker of regret, or maybe guilt. But it was fleeting, and it vanished just as quickly as it had come.

"I am what I had to become," Mydei said softly. "And you—" he paused, his voice low and tinged with sorrow, "You were never meant to follow me."

Phainon's breath shuddered in his chest as he forced himself to meet Mydei's eyes. The years between them, the hurt, the betrayal—it was all there, staring back at him. And yet, beneath it all, there was something more—something that had never truly been lost.

"I'm still here," Phainon whispered, his voice breaking. "I'm still fighting. For you, for us. I won't give up."

But Mydei only shook his head, a sad, weary smile on his lips. "It's already over, Phainon. The world has already decided."

The words were a death sentence. They cut through the silence, leaving Phainon raw and trembling in the cold night. For the first time in years, he felt the true weight of what he had lost, and what he had fought for.

But in the distance, far beyond the ruins of Kremnos, Phainon felt something stir. It wasn't the end. It couldn't be.

"I'll stop you," Phainon said, standing up slowly, wiping the tears that had gathered at the corners of his eyes. "I'll stop you, Mydei. Even if it costs me everything."

Mydei's gaze softened, and for a fleeting moment, it almost seemed like he might say something. But then he turned, walking away into the shadows of Kremnos, leaving Phainon standing there, broken yet still standing.

The battle had just begun.

The air between them crackled with tension, a storm brewing from the weight of their shared history, their broken past. Each strike Phainon delivered rang out with the force of a thousand questions, each swing of his blade more than just an attack—it was the culmination of years of rage, betrayal, and grief, coiling into a singular, violent crescendo. The ground beneath them shook with the force of their blows, the ruins of Kremnos bearing witness to the clash of two souls irreparably torn apart by fate.

For every move Phainon made, Mydei countered with that same deadly grace, his body fluid, his movements precise, as though the battle were some sort of twisted dance. But there was something different about him now. The fierce, arrogant fire that had once fueled their rivalry had dulled to something colder, more resigned.

Then, in a moment that stretched like eternity, Phainon's sword found a crack in Mydei's defense. His blade sliced through the air with a sickening hiss, catching Mydei off guard, and in that split second, Phainon found the upper hand.

With a sudden, brutal motion, he knocked Mydei to the ground, pinning him beneath his weight, his breath coming in sharp, ragged bursts. His sword hovered at Mydei's throat, the tip just inches from skin, but he didn't strike. He couldn't.

Mydei’s gaze met his, not with defiance, but with an unsettling calm, as though he had long since made peace with whatever Phainon was about to do. He didn’t struggle, didn’t fight back.

Instead, his lips curled into a bitter smile, his voice a low murmur that sent a chill down Phainon’s spine. “What now?” Mydei’s eyes bore into him, unblinking, unwavering. “Will you end the torment that tears at me? Torture me and bleed me dry? Cut off my arms and legs and abandon me, exposed and alone, as I fall into madness?”

Phainon’s heart stuttered in his chest, his grip on his sword tightening, his breath uneven. Mydei’s words were like daggers, each one aimed directly at the heart of the pain Phainon had been carrying for so long. He could feel it—the weight of the moment, the bitterness, the loss that had festered between them for so many years.

“We’ll go ahead,” Mydei continued, his voice eerily calm, almost resigned, “Do it. End it, if you must. But know this—there is no salvation for me. You can’t kill what’s already dead. I won’t die. Not by your hand, not by anyone’s.”

Phainon’s heart hammered in his chest as he stared down at Mydei. It was madness. Mydei was practically daring him to end it—to end his suffering. But Phainon knew the truth of it. Mydei couldn’t die. He was a mockery of life, cursed to endure this torment forever, caught between existence and nothingness.

His hand shook, the sword trembling in his grip, but still, Phainon didn’t strike.

“Why not me?” The words came out before Phainon could stop them, his voice raw, his chest tight with emotion. His eyes flickered with something—anger, desperation, something that he couldn’t name.

“Why didn’t you stay for me, Mydei?” he whispered, the question cutting through the air like a blade of its own. “Why didn’t you kill me too? Why didn’t you stay? Was I never enough for you? Why… why was I never enough?”

Phainon’s heart felt like it was being ripped from his chest. He barely held on to his composure, the shaking in his hands growing worse, his body trembling with the weight of the question he couldn’t get out of his mind.

Mydei’s expression softened, but there was no warmth in it. Just a cold, aching acceptance, as though he had already given up on anything resembling a future, a life, a meaning.

“I was never the one who needed to die,” Mydei whispered, his voice almost a breath, barely audible. “You were. You.”

Phainon’s chest tightened at the words, the weight of them pressing down on him with unbearable force. Mydei’s gaze never wavered, and in that moment, Phainon realized the depth of the abyss that had opened between them. There was no going back. Not anymore.

His throat tightened, his heart breaking with a pain too deep to articulate. He stood there, staring at Mydei, his hands trembling, the weight of the moment crushing him from every angle. The sword in his grip felt heavier than ever, and with a strangled cry, he threw it aside, the blade clattering to the ground as his shoulders sagged. His breath came in ragged gasps, his whole body shaking with the intensity of everything he was feeling.

But there was no release. No salvation in ending it. Mydei was still here. Alive. Immortal.

“I never wanted this,” Phainon muttered, his voice breaking with the rawness of his grief. “I never wanted any of this. But I don’t know how to fix it. I don’t know how to make it stop.”

His eyes flickered down to the sword, discarded on the ground, and then back to Mydei. The thought of ending it all — ending his own pain, the burden, the endless torment that had followed him for so long — seemed to evaporate in the air. Phainon had wanted the world to end in that moment, but Mydei was still here, tormenting him with his existence.

There was no victory in this. No relief. Only the suffocating weight of a fate already sealed.

Every breath felt like a betrayal—of his purpose, of the mission, of the very world he had fought for. He didn't know who he was anymore. There was nothing left to fight for. Mydei's betrayal had destroyed any sense of certainty. It had cracked him wide open, leaving nothing but the hollow sound of his own desperate gasps for meaning.

Phainon staggered back, his body sinking to the ground, his hands shaking as they pressed against his face. The world around him felt distant, as though everything had lost its color, its depth. What was the point in standing, in breathing, in fighting any longer? The Heirs were dead, the world broken, and Mydei—he wasn't just a traitor. He was the very embodiment of all that had crumbled. And Phainon had been left behind to watch it all burn.

"I don't even know why I'm still here," he whispered to the empty air, the words tasting like ash on his tongue. The wind whistled through the ruined streets, but the sound felt more like a mockery than any kind of comfort. "What's left to save? Who am I saving?"

His fingers dug into the dirt, grounding himself in the reality of the destruction. He could feel the blood on his hands, even though it wasn't his own. He could feel the weight of every life lost, every promise broken, and the crushing weight of his own failure. His eyes burned with unshed tears, but he refused to let them fall. He was beyond that. There was no place for tears anymore.

Phainon had always been the hero. The Deliverer. The one who would save them all. But that was before Mydei shattered everything—before he tore apart the very foundation of their purpose.

Now, he was nothing. No one. Just a man trapped in the ruins of his own expectations.

And Mydei? He wasn't dead. He wasn't gone. He was still there, still breathing, still tormenting Phainon with his very existence. It was almost too much to bear. The man who had once been his rival, his equal—had become something unrecognizable, something that cut deeper than any blade ever could.

Phainon’s chest tightened, his breaths coming in shallow gasps. The weight of everything crushed him. The silence was suffocating. Was he supposed to just keep going? Was there still a reason to keep fighting when all that awaited him was more death, more pain, more failure?

He couldn’t see a way forward anymore.

And that realization—that crippling truth—was the final blow.

“Maybe this is what you wanted, Mydei,” Phainon muttered, his voice raw with bitterness. “To break me. To watch me wither away.”

For a long moment, he sat there, consumed by the silence and the weight of the world that had caved in around him. The pieces of his once unshakable resolve scattered like dust in the wind.

There was no coming back from this. How many times has he thought this? No coming back, no coming back, no fucking way of coming back.

Phainon is tired.

He couldn’t even stand anymore. His knees buckled beneath him, and he collapsed onto the ground, his hand pressing against the earth that felt so far removed from him now. The weight of everything—of the lives lost, the years wasted, the decisions made—settled over him like a dark blanket.

His body screamed for rest. His soul ached for an end.

It was all so futile.

He thought of Mydei. He thought of those final moments, standing over him, the eyes that had once burned with passion now cold and indifferent. That final, deadly blow. The betrayal that would forever haunt him. Phainon wondered, briefly, if that was the moment he truly died—not physically, but the death of everything he had once believed in.

And yet, despite all the pain, despite everything that had shattered within him, Phainon couldn’t help but yearn for one more moment with him. Just one more. To know why Mydei had chosen this path, why he had betrayed them all.

Suddenly, there was a shift in the air—an energy he couldn’t deny. A presence, heavy and familiar.

Phainon lifted his head slowly, his heart faltering as he looked up. Mydei stood before him, no longer a distant figure, but so close Phainon could feel the tension of his existence in every breath.

“Mydei…” Phainon’s voice was a broken whisper, barely audible over the sound of his own racing heartbeat. It was as though his body had forgotten how to feel, how to speak.

Mydei’s gaze, dark and knowing, rested on him. His eyes were tired too, in a way that Phainon had never seen before. There was no mockery now, no cruel smirk on his lips. Just the weight of everything between them, suffocating and endless.

Phainon pushed himself up, but the effort was too much. His body refused him. His arms shook, his legs unsteady.

And Mydei… Mydei didn’t stop him.

The silence stretched between them, an abyss that neither could cross. Mydei’s presence was both a comfort and a curse. Every step he took was one that Phainon had once longed for. But now, it only hurt.

“I’m so tired,” Phainon muttered, the words barely a breath. “I’m so tired of it all… Mydei, why didn’t you kill me? Why didn’t you take me with you? What’s the point of me living on like this?”

His voice cracked on the last words, raw with desperation. He didn’t care. His anger and grief were spilling out now, uncontrollable.

Mydei stood still, not answering at first, only watching him. The tension in the air thickened.

“I never wanted this,” Phainon continued, his voice shaking with the weight of his thoughts. “I never wanted any of this. But I don’t know how to fix it. I don’t know how to make it stop.”

Mydei’s eyes softened, but only slightly, before he took a step forward.

“You were never meant to die, Phainon, not physically,” Mydei said quietly, his voice low but clear. “You weren’t supposed to carry the weight of the world. That’s why I had to live, to show you it could never be saved. But you still keep breathing, still keep fighting.”

Phainon shook his head, the words cutting deeper than any blade could. He hadn’t asked for this—had never wanted it. He hadn’t wanted to be the hero, the Deliverer. But he had tried to live up to it, tried to believe that everything could be saved, even when he knew deep down it was a lie.

“But you keep breathing too, Mydei,” Phainon spat, his voice thick with the weight of his own misery. “Why didn’t you let me die with you? Why didn’t you—” He choked on his own words, unable to finish the question.

Mydei’s eyes hardened, and he closed the space between them, his presence towering and intense. His gaze held no warmth, no affection. Just the cold, unyielding truth of everything that had transpired.

“Because,” Mydei began, his voice barely above a whisper, “it would have been too easy.”

Phainon stared at him, disbelief written across his face. He wanted to understand, to make sense of it all. But there was nothing that made sense anymore.

“You’re still alive because I couldn’t let you off that easy,” Mydei continued, his voice strained, as if the weight of those words cost him something. “You needed to see it. To see the world crumble, the way it was

always meant to. To understand what's truly broken. And you needed to live with the pain of knowing that nothing you do will ever change it."

Phainon felt a sharp pang in his chest as he took in Mydei's words. It was cruel, but it was also the truth. He had lived with that pain for years now. The truth of it gnawed at him, a constant, relentless ache.

"And yet," Mydei continued, his voice barely audible, "you're still here. After everything. You're still standing."

Phainon's breath hitched. He didn't know what to say. His mind was a whirlwind of thoughts, of anger, of guilt, of confusion. Why was he still here? Why couldn't he just end it all? Why couldn't Mydei end it?

"I wanted to die with you," Phainon whispered, the words escaping before he could stop them. "I wanted it to end with you.

Mydei's expression softened, a faint flicker of something in his eyes that Phainon couldn't quite place. "You wanted to end it all… but you're still here, Phainon. And as long as you're breathing, you can make something of it."

Phainon looked at Mydei, his heart heavy with the weight of everything they had been through, everything they had lost. He had thought he would find closure in Mydei's presence. But now, standing before him, it felt as though they were both trapped in a never-ending cycle. Mydei had shown him the truth. But Phainon wasn't sure if he could bear it.

"Then what now?" Phainon whispered, his voice cracked and defeated. "What's the point of any of it?"

Mydei's lips curled into something that was almost a smile, but there was no joy in it. "The point is that you're still alive. And I'm still here. Maybe that's all we get."

Phainon closed his eyes, letting the weight of Mydei's words sink in. Maybe that was all they would ever get.

And with that, Phainon made a decision. He wouldn’t kill Mydei. He wouldn’t be the one to end it. The world was too broken for that. But he would keep going. Even if it meant facing this endless pain, this endless torment.

He would keep breathing.

Even if he couldn’t save it.

Even if he couldn’t save himself.

And as Mydei turned and disappeared into the shadows, Phainon stood alone once more, the weight of the world pressing down on him, but his heart—strangely, finally—at peace.

End Notes

Thank you for anyone who stuck around this long! Ughhh this took forever to post, but I hope you enjoyed it.

If you guys think the pacing is off somewhere or I can improve anything, PLEASEE tell me. I wanna be a better writer, especially in this department, in fact, I think this is my first angst fic actually.

I wanted to end it in smut or something, but I felt it wouldn't match the tone of the story, and it made me feel like a degenerate, so unfortunately no sex😔

I'm planning or maybe writing something in a few weeks or months maybe happy if I have time because I hate sad endings, or just another alt au with Phainon going rouge, but we'll see.

Anyway, thanks for reading!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!